

Main Idea - Study Guide

A focused guide for finding what a whole passage is mainly saying - not just what it is about.

The core question

If you had to explain the passage in one accurate sentence, what would you say the author wants the reader to understand?

1. Topic, main idea, and summary are different

Term	What it means	Example
Topic	The subject	city trees
Main idea	What the text says about the subject	City trees can reduce heat, but their benefits depend on where and how they are planted.
Summary	The main idea plus the most important supporting points	A short account of the passage that keeps the central idea and major details.

2. How exam-style questions usually ask it

- Direct: Which statement best expresses the central idea of the passage?

- Implied: Which statement best expresses an idea developed throughout the passage?
- Equivalent: Which statement best states the author's main point?

The wording may change. The task stays the same: choose the idea that fits the passage as a whole.

3. Explicit vs. implied main idea

Explicit main idea: the author states the point fairly directly, often near the beginning or end.

Implied main idea: no single sentence gives the whole answer. You have to combine repeated details, examples, and conclusions.

4. A four-step method

1. Name the topic. What subject appears again and again?
2. Notice the repeated direction. What do several important details show about that topic?
3. Write a one-sentence point. Finish: "The author mainly shows that..."
4. Test every option against the whole passage. A correct answer should fit the beginning, middle, and end.

Common Distractors

The answers that look right - but are not

Trap	What it does
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Supporting detail	Uses a true fact from the passage, but it is only one piece of the larger point.
Too narrow	Covers one paragraph, example, or event instead of the whole passage.
Too broad	Makes a claim bigger than the author supports.
True but incomplete	Captures part of the passage but misses an important qualification or second half.
Unsupported generalization	Sounds sensible, but the passage does not provide enough evidence for it.

Worked example 1 - explicit main idea

A community center replaced its old fluorescent lights with LED fixtures. The new lights use less electricity and last longer, so maintenance workers replace bulbs less often. The center paid more at the beginning, but its monthly electricity bill dropped during the first year. Staff members plan to use the savings to help fund other building improvements.

Question: Which statement best expresses the central idea?

- A. Maintenance workers dislike replacing fluorescent bulbs.
- B. LED lights cost more than fluorescent lights in every building.
- C. The community center expects its LED upgrade to reduce energy and maintenance costs over time.

D. The community center should spend all of its savings on new lighting.

Best answer: C

It covers the whole passage: the upgrade, lower energy use, less maintenance, and the long-term financial benefit. A is only a detail, B overgeneralizes, and D adds a recommendation the passage never makes.

Worked example 2 - implied main idea

When the town first opened a weekend farmers market, only eight vendors registered. By the end of the first summer, more than twenty sellers were attending regularly. Nearby cafes began opening earlier on market days, and the library started holding Saturday programs because more families were already downtown. The town later added bicycle racks and shaded seating around the square.

Question: Which statement best expresses an idea developed throughout the passage?

- A. The farmers market became part of a wider increase in weekend activity downtown.
- B. The library is the most popular place in town on Saturdays.
- C. Bicycle racks caused more vendors to register for the market.
- D. Every town should open a weekend farmers market.

Best answer: A

No sentence states this idea exactly, but the vendor growth, cafe hours, library programs, and town improvements all point to the same larger change.

Quick check before you choose

- Does the answer cover the whole passage?
- Is it more than one true detail?
- Does it keep the author's limits and qualifications?
- Can I point to several parts of the text that support it?
- Does it avoid adding a new opinion or recommendation?

Use this guide with the Main Idea Practice Workbook, then use the interactive practice for immediate feedback.